

# The Noble Perfection of Wisdom Called Kauśika

Ārya Kauśikaprajñāpāramitā Nāma · Toh 554 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཤེས་རབ་ཀྱི་ཕྱི་རོལ་ཏུ་ཕྱུག་པ་ཀུའི་ཀུ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ།

Toh 554 in the Kangyur is a Perfection of Wisdom sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Kauśika Prajñāpāramitā and in Tibetan as the Phags pa shes rab kyi pha rol tu phyin pa kau shi ka, meaning "The Noble Perfection of Wisdom Called Kauśika." It belongs to the Prajñāpāramitā class of texts and takes the form of a teaching delivered by the Buddha at Vulture Peak Mountain near Rājagṛha, addressed specifically to Śakra, the lord of the gods, whose epithet Kauśika gives the text its name. The discourse expounds the nature of the Perfection of Wisdom through a series of paradoxical formulations — neither two nor not-two, neither marked nor without marks — pointing beyond conceptual elaboration to the non-dual character of wisdom itself. As one of the shorter Prajñāpāramitā sūtras preserved in the Kangyur, it distills the essential insight of the broader Perfection of Wisdom literature into a concise and direct exchange.

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In the language of India: Ārya Kauśika Prajñāpāramitā Nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Perfection of Wisdom Called Kauśika.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha on Vulture Peak Mountain together with a great Saṅgha of monks and with many hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas, all of them youthful.

Then the Blessed One declared to Śakra, lord of the gods — Kauśika, this is the meaning of the Perfection of Wisdom:

The Perfection of Wisdom is not to be regarded as two, nor as not-two. It is not marked by signs, nor is it without signs. It is neither to be taken up nor to be cast aside. It is neither something to be added to nor something without addition. It is neither defiled nor undefiled. It is neither purified nor unpurified. It is neither to be abandoned nor not abandoned. It is neither an abiding place nor a non-abiding place. It is neither to be engaged with nor not engaged with. It is neither connected nor unconnected. It is neither a condition nor a non-condition. It is neither a phenomenon nor a non-phenomenon. It is neither suchness nor non-suchness. It is neither the ultimate limit nor not the ultimate limit.

Kauśika, in just this way the meaning of the Perfection of Wisdom is as follows:

Because all phenomena are equal, the Perfection of Wisdom itself is equal.

Because all phenomena are profound, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound.

Because all phenomena are solitary and secluded, the Perfection of Wisdom is solitary and secluded.

Because all phenomena are without movement, the Perfection of Wisdom is without movement.

Because all phenomena are without conceit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without conceit.

Because all phenomena are without fear, the Perfection of Wisdom is without fear.

Because all phenomena are without shame or embarrassment, the Perfection of Wisdom is without shame or embarrassment.

Because all phenomena are of a single taste, the Perfection of Wisdom is of a single taste.

Because all phenomena are without arising, the Perfection of Wisdom is without arising.

Because all phenomena are without cessation, the Perfection of Wisdom is without cessation.

Because all phenomena are like space, the Perfection of Wisdom is like space.

Because form is boundless, the Perfection of Wisdom is boundless. Likewise, because feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are boundless, the Perfection of Wisdom is boundless.

Because the earth element is boundless, the Perfection of Wisdom is boundless. Likewise, because the water element, the fire element, the wind element, the space element, and the consciousness element are boundless, the Perfection of Wisdom is boundless.

Because Mount Meru is boundless, the Perfection of Wisdom is boundless.

Because the ocean is boundless, the Perfection of Wisdom is boundless.

Because the vajra is equal, the Perfection of Wisdom is equal.

Because all phenomena are undivided, the Perfection of Wisdom is undivided.

Because the essential nature of all phenomena is not an object of apprehension, the essential nature of the Perfection of Wisdom is not an object of apprehension.

Because all phenomena are equal with nothing removed, the Perfection of Wisdom is equal with nothing removed.

Because all phenomena are without agency, the Perfection of Wisdom is without agency.

Because all phenomena are inconceivable, the Perfection of Wisdom is inconceivable.

Likewise, the Perfection of Generosity, the Perfection of Moral Discipline, the Perfection of Patience, the Perfection of Diligence, the Perfection of Meditative Concentration, the Perfection of Wisdom, the Perfection of Skillful Means, the Perfection of Aspiration, the Perfection of Power, and the Perfection of Gnosis — because the three spheres are thoroughly pure, the Perfection of Wisdom is boundless.

What is called the Perfection of Wisdom is this: the eighteen emptinesses, which are as follows. The emptiness of the inner. The emptiness of the outer. The emptiness of both outer and inner. The emptiness of emptiness. The great emptiness. The emptiness of the ultimate. The emptiness of the conditioned. The emptiness of the unconditioned. The emptiness that transcends extremes. The emptiness of that which has neither beginning nor end. The emptiness of what is not to be cast aside. The emptiness of intrinsic nature. The emptiness of all phenomena. The emptiness of defining characteristics. The emptiness of the non-apprehensible. The emptiness of non-existence. The emptiness of essential nature. The emptiness of the essential nature of non-existence. In brief, this emptiness is what is called the Perfection of Wisdom.

Like a star, a flaw in the eye, a lamp,  
A magical illusion, dew, a water bubble,  
A dream, a flash of lightning, and a cloud —  
So should all conditioned things be regarded.

Homage to the Blessed Noble Perfection of Wisdom.  
Om dhīḥ hrīḥ śrī śruti smṛti mati gati vijaye svāhā.

Neither ceasing nor arising,  
Neither annihilated nor permanent,  
Not many in meaning, yet not one,  
Neither coming nor going —  
The one who teaches dependent origination,  
Whose peace has stilled all conceptual elaboration,  
Who is a fully awakened buddha —  
To that supreme speaker I pay homage.

Having thus spoken, the Blessed One concluded. The venerable Śāradvatīputra, Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods), those monks, those

bodhisattvas, and the world together with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had proclaimed.

The noble Perfection of Wisdom known as the Kauśika is complete.

## Translator's Notes

- The opening phrase "□□□□□□□□□□ □□" indicates the end of a preceding text on the same manuscript or block, and is not part of this sūtra's title or body; it has been omitted from the translation as it belongs to the prior work.

The term rendered "without shame or embarrassment" translates a term literally meaning "without bashfulness" or "without conscience-based inhibition," which in Tibetan Buddhist psychology can carry a technical sense of the mental factor of moral shame. In context here, however, it functions as one of a series of qualitative descriptions of the Perfection of Wisdom as beyond psychological conditioning, and "without shame or embarrassment" captures the sense for a general listener.

The phrase rendered "the ultimate limit" translates a term meaning "the perfect or true end," referring to the absolute limit of reality, sometimes rendered "the limit of reality" or "the final real." This is a standard Perfection of Wisdom locution for ultimate truth or the terminus of all possible understanding.

- The passage lists ten perfections rather than the usual six, reflecting the expanded tenfold scheme found in Mahāyāna sūtras such as the Daśabhūmikasūtra. The additional four are skillful means, aspiration, power, and gnosis.

The phrase "three spheres thoroughly pure" refers to the triad of agent, object, and action being free of inherent existence — a standard Mahāyāna formulation for non-conceptual giving and other perfections.

The concluding mantra syllables are transliterated Sanskrit and are rendered phonetically as they appear; their precise canonical form varies across witnesses.

The closing verse of homage is a well-known verse attributed to Nāgārjuna, found at the opening of his Mūlamadhyamakakārikā, here serving as a colophonic salutation.

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## Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly

proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.  
May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.